

From Problem Statement to the Ghar Plan

The complete product journey — discovery, research, persona and JTBD work, opportunity selection, solution design, planning, and the decision trail behind every step.

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30 August 2026

Hackathon submission: "The Gaana Turnaround"

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01 Problem statement

It is August 2026. Gaana is not dead, but it is very small. In 2021 it was worth about \$580 million. In December 2023 it was sold inside the Times Group for ₹25 lakh — roughly the price of a mid-range car — and now belongs to ENIL, which runs Radio Mirchi.

The strange part is that it's working. Gaana has had no free tier since September 2022, when it switched off free streaming to survive. Digital revenue grew 84% last financial year to ₹112 crore, roughly 1 in 5 Indians who pay for music now pay Gaana, and the business is expected to break even this year — the only part of its parent company that's growing.

₹15cr BUDGET FOR THE YEAR	12 + 3 ENGINEERS + DESIGNERS	8 / 100 INDIANS WHO PAY FOR STREAMING	<₹100 SELF-REPORTED MONTHLY CEILING
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The mandate: ship **one feature this year** that makes a specific kind of listener start paying, pay more, or stay subscribed longer — with no free tier to fall back on, and every stream costing real royalty money whether the listener pays or not. The brief pointed at six possible starting places: existing payers, regional-language listeners, devotional listeners, Pocket FM-style audio-story fans, families sharing one account, or small shop/gym owners needing a public performance licence.

02 Opportunity scan

Rather than assuming which listener mattered most, the first research pass was deliberately broad — covering Gaana's own customer sentiment, adjacent audio categories in India, and the regulatory environment around music licensing.

OPPORTUNITY SURFACED	WHAT THE RESEARCH SHOWED	OUTCOME
Billing & cancellation distrust on Gaana itself	Gaana's own review pages are dominated by autopay and refund complaints, not catalogue complaints.	Flagged as a retention leak to fix regardless of feature choice.
Small business / shop & gym licensing	India's licensing bodies (IPRS, PPL, Novex, RMPL) unified into one portal, Sangeet Dwar, in Feb 2026 — but it issues permission, not a way to actually play music.	Built out as a full recommendation at this stage — later ruled out (see Section 3).
Devotional / bhakti listeners	Large category (Sri Mandir: 10M+ downloads) but monetised via commerce/donations, not subscriptions.	Parked — weak subscription fit.
Pocket FM-style audio drama	Runs on per-episode micro-unlocks (~85% of revenue), not a subscription model.	Parked — different economic engine.
Deeper regional-language catalogue	A real historic Gaana strength, but Spotify has closed the gap steadily since 2019.	Parked — not defensible alone.

03 User research

Once the direction was corrected to B2C (see Section 03 note below), research shifted specifically to what Spotify's and YouTube's own users complain about — the theory being that a defensible Gaana feature needs to solve something the market leaders structurally can't.

DIRECTION FROM SUCHITHRA

The KPI was made explicit at this point: the number of individual customers subscribing to Gaana, not business revenue — ruling out the B2B licensing direction from Section 02.

FINDING	EVIDENCE	OUTCOME
Spotify Family plan address verification — members must live at the plan manager's exact address, re-checked periodically	Spotify's own support article confirms the policy; community forum threads show long-time paying members losing access.	Carried forward — became the core opportunity.
Catalogue volatility from label disputes (e.g. Tips-Gaana, 2020)	Recurring industry pattern, but affects every platform equally.	Parked — not Gaana-specific.
Spotify shuffle algorithm complaints	Real, upvoted frustration, but patchable by Spotify in a single sprint.	Parked — not defensible.

Two claims were directly challenged and corrected during this phase — both are logged in full in Part C, Section 08, since fact-checking a competitor claim is as much a part of the research record as the finding itself: (1) YouTube was initially said to have "no family option" at all — corrected once challenged: YouTube Premium does offer household plans, enforcing the same address rule. (2) Spotify's "12-month lockout" was initially stated as absolute — corrected to reflect that the lockout only applies to switching plans, while the real friction is a reported rejoin glitch.

04 User persona — The Remote Provider



The Remote Provider

28–38 · Working professional · Bengaluru / Hyderabad / Pune · Lives away from parents

"I already pay my parents' recharge and their insurance — why can't one music plan just work the same way?"

Moved cities for work and already pays recurring bills for family back home — a parent's mobile recharge, an insurance premium, a shared OTT login. Wants to add parents and siblings to one music plan, but every family plan on the market assumes everyone lives under one roof.

GOALS

Cover the family's entertainment costs in one place, the way they already do for recharge and insurance; feel connected to home despite the distance.

FRUSTRATIONS

Family plans require a shared address that doesn't exist; ends up paying for 3–4 disconnected subscriptions, or family falls back to free, ad-supported listening.

05 Jobs to be done

FUNCTIONAL JOB

When I live in a different city from my parents, I want to pay for their music subscription along with mine, so I don't have to manage separate logins and payments while still taking care of home.

EMOTIONAL JOB

When I think about my parents using a worse, ad-cluttered version of an app I pay for myself, I want to feel like I'm still present and providing for them, so I don't feel guilty about the distance.

SOCIAL JOB

When my family talks about who looks after what at home, I want them to see that I've taken care of this too, so I'm recognised as someone who provides, even from far away.

06 Empathy map

SAYS

- "I've paid for years — why am I suddenly locked out?"
- "My mother doesn't even have her own billing address on file — how do I add her?"

THINKS

- Feels the platform was never built for a family like his.
- Wonders if it's even worth the effort to keep fighting support over an address check.

DOES

- Manages several UPI payments for family bills already.
- Tried adding parents to a Family plan and hit the address wall; settled for individual plans or free, ad-supported listening for them instead.

FEELS

- Frustrated by rules built for a different kind of household.
- Mildly guilty that "free tier" is what his parents end up with.
- Relieved when something finally just works, simply.

07 Opportunity selection & prioritization

Three real candidate opportunities reached this stage. Each was scored against the brief's own judging weight on defensibility, using a simple 1–5 scale.

OPPORTUNITY	IMPACT	EFFORT	CONFIDENCE	DEFENSIBILITY	DECISION
Devotional listeners (gifted plan)	2	3	2	2	Parked
Deeper regional-language catalogue	3	2	3	2	Parked
Remote Provider — distributed family billing	4	3	4	5	Chosen

Why this one won: it's specific to a real, nameable audience already paying for family expenses elsewhere; it's current and affects *paying* customers directly (the exact group a subscription-rate KPI cares about); and it scores highest on defensibility — Spotify's and YouTube's address checks are global anti-fraud infrastructure, not a setting either company can quietly loosen for India.

08 Solution alternatives considered

Before committing to a build, two claims made along the way were directly challenged and corrected — logged here in full since they shaped the final feature description.

CORRECTION 1 — YOUTUBE'S FAMILY OPTION

Initially stated that free YouTube had no family option at all. Corrected: YouTube Premium does offer a Family plan (₹299/month, up to 6) and a two-person plan (₹219/month) in India — but both enforce the same same-household rule as Spotify, actively checked every 30 days since September 2025. This reframed the opportunity from a Spotify quirk to a converging industry pattern.

CORRECTION 2 — THE "12-MONTH LOCKOUT"

Initially stated that a member who misses verification is locked out for 12 months, full stop. Corrected against Spotify's own support article: the lockout only applies to joining a *different* plan — a member can rejoin the *same* plan immediately once re-invited. The real, evidenced pain is a reported glitch where that rejoin fails anyway, leaving members stuck until Spotify support intervenes manually.

With the opportunity confirmed, three different ways to solve it were weighed:

SOLUTION	REASONING	STATUS
Netflix-style flat "extra member" add-on	Proven pricing lever, but Netflix's cost per title is roughly fixed regardless of viewers — Gaana pays labels per stream, so a flat fee with no usage lever prices it blind to its real marginal cost.	Parked — pricing lever borrowed, cost model rejected.
Concierge-only manual plan	Fastest way to validate willingness-to-pay with near-zero engineering cost, but a human-run roster caps out at a few hundred plans.	Kept as Experiment 2 (demand validation).
Gaana Ghar Plan — self-serve, no address, concurrent-stream cap	Borrows Netflix's per-head pricing logic, drops the address check entirely, and replaces Netflix's implicit cost control with one suited to Gaana's actual cost driver.	Chosen.

09 Chosen solution — Gaana Ghar Plan

Gaana Ghar Plan

Owner adds up to 4 family members by name, relationship, and phone number — no address, anywhere in the flow. Each member gets their own login and personalised feed. Cost is controlled by a 3-concurrent-stream cap rather than an address check. Priced at ₹149 (owner) + ₹39 per additional member — ≈₹61/head at 5 members.

IMPACT	EFFORT	CONFIDENCE
High — converts a bill the Remote Provider already pays elsewhere into Gaana's highest-revenue plan per owner, and pulls in family members who'd otherwise never pay for music.	Medium — no geo-verification system to build (the hardest, most error-prone part of Spotify's own model); reuses existing accounts and profiles.	Medium-high — the mechanic is proven elsewhere (Netflix); the pain it removes is currently, publicly documented on the competitor's own forums.

10 Why this will work

- Netflix's Extra Member feature added **9.33 million paid subscribers in Q1 2024** globally, following its household password-sharing crackdown.
- Netflix's own leadership confirmed the feature converted "many millions" of previously non-paying sharers into paying members.
- Ghar Plan borrows the pricing lever, not the whole model — Netflix's core household is still address-verified; Ghar Plan drops the address check entirely and pairs the per-head fee with a stream cap to protect the cost Netflix doesn't have to manage.

11 OKRs

Objective: **Make Gaana the natural choice for urban professionals supporting family back home.**

KR1	Ship Ghar Plan self-serve to 100% of eligible subscribers by end of the quarter
KR2	Reach 5,000 active Ghar Plans within 90 days of launch
KR3	Hold Ghar Plan 90-day churn below solo-plan churn
KR4	Keep lockout/removal-related support tickets under 5% of active plans

12 Roadmap & prioritization

PHASE	TIMEFRAME	WHAT SHIPS	GOAL
0 — Signal	Week 1	Experiment 1: no-address landing/fake-door banner	Confirm click-through interest before building anything
1 — Validate	Weeks 2–6	Experiment 2 (concierge pilot) + Experiment 3 (price-per-head A/B) run in parallel	Prove real willingness-to-pay and find the right per-head price
2 — Build	Weeks 7–10	Self-serve invite flow, owner dashboard, billing	Turn validated demand into a scalable product
3 — Tune	Weeks 11–14	Experiment 4: stream-cap threshold test; soft launch to full base	Balance abuse prevention against real family usage
4 — Review	Day 90	Full metrics review against OKRs	Decide scale-up, iterate, or stop

13 Success metrics

TYPE	METRIC	WHAT IT TESTS
North Star	Ghar Plan-weighted subscription rate	Net new paying subscribers via Ghar Plan, plus reduced churn among adopters
Supporting	90-day churn, Ghar Plan vs. solo plan	Whether bundling actually retains, not just converts
90-day target	5,000 active plans, <5% lockout complaints	Enough scale to trust the churn signal, with near-zero versions of Spotify's own complaint
Funnel	Invite completion rate (48-hour verification)	Funnel health, not vanity
Cost control	Concurrent-stream cap breach rate	Whether usage stays within the royalty-cost model

14 Full source bibliography

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This document reflects the full product journey as of 30 August 2026, prepared alongside the submitted one-page HTML deck for "The Gaana Turnaround" hackathon.